F O R G E

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

"We're building a new prison experience — where men lead by example, support one another, and prepare to make a positive impact — both inside these walls and beyond them."

A Peer-Led, Evidence-Based Mentorship Program

Dooly State Prison • Unadilla, Georgia

Positive Outreach Development Society, Inc.

FORGE

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

A Peer-Led Mentorship Program at Dooly State Prison

FORGE is a 36-week, evidence-based program that trains incarcerated men to become certified peer mentors — reducing dorm conflict, strengthening rehabilitation programming, and building a safer facility for inmates and staff alike.

What FORGE Does

FORGE prepares men to facilitate evidence-based programs, mediate conflicts, lead restorative circles, and model accountability across housing units. Mentors operate within clearly defined boundaries — they do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, or replace staff authority.

The program creates a **self-sustaining pipeline**: certified mentors from each cohort train the next, building permanent infrastructure.

Over 790 pages of curriculum. 108 scripted sessions. Built from programs that cut recidivism to near zero and reduced violence by 80%. This isn't theory — it's the most comprehensive peer mentor training system ever developed for a Georgia prison.

The 36-Week Curriculum

108 sessions. 3 per week. 2 hours each. Three phases with formal gate requirements:

Phase 1: Foundation
Weeks 1–12
"Know Yourself" — CBT, emotional regulation, conflict resolution

Phase 2: Development
Weeks 13–24
"Build Others" — Facilitation, MI, simulation training

Phase 3: Practicum
Weeks 25–36
"Lead & Serve" — Supervised mentoring, 60+ hrs, certification

Built on Evidence That Works

Curriculum from **Thinking for a Change** (NIC), **Moral Reconation Therapy**, **GRIP** (California), **Seeking Safety**, **SAMHSA Trauma-Informed Framework**. Structure from **PEP** (Texas), **RSVP** (San Francisco), **Defy Ventures**, **Oregon Mentors Certification Program**.

0.5%	80%	43%	$5 : $1	85%
GRIP recidivism (vs. 41.9% state avg)	Reduction in violent rearrests (RSVP)	Less likely to recidivate (RAND meta-analysis)	Return on investment (RAND Corporation)	Employment within 6 months (Defy)

What Participants Learn

Phase 1: Personal Development

- Identify and interrupt thinking errors (CBT)
- Manage emotions using the escalation curve
- 4-4-4 breathing & 5-4-3-2-1 grounding
- Assertive communication & "I" statements
- FORGE 5-step conflict resolution model
- Accountability spectrum & impact awareness
- Growth mindset & future visioning

Phase 2: Mentor Skills

- Adult learning principles & lesson planning
- Motivational interviewing (OARS framework)
- Simulation-based scenario training
- Restorative justice circles
- Crisis de-escalation protocols
- Co-facilitation practice with peer feedback
- Ethics, boundaries & confidentiality

Phase 3: Field Leadership

- Supervised co-facilitation of Phase 1 sessions
- 1-on-1 mentoring with new participants
- Independent session delivery (observed)
- Community circle facilitation
- Real-time conflict mediation
- Self-care & burnout prevention
- Review board & formal certification

The Self-Sustaining Mentor Pipeline

Cohort 1 — Trained by program founders → **Graduates** — Become certified mentors → **Train Cohort 2** — Co-facilitate Phase 1 for next group → **Cycle Repeats** — Permanent mentor infrastructure

What This Means for Staff

FORGE-certified mentors are trained to make your job easier — not harder. They handle the low-level tensions that drain your time, support the programs that need reliable facilitators, and build a dorm culture where problems get solved before they reach your desk.

De-escalation Before Incidents
Mentors intervene early in peer conflicts, reducing use-of-force situations

Trained, Not Self-Appointed
216 hours of training, 60+ field hours, formal certification by review board

Clear Role Boundaries
Mentors never investigate, discipline, override staff, or conceal concerns

Measurable Accountability
6 competencies scored, peer & staff evaluation, removable for violations

FORGE supports institutional safety. The goal is stability, not control.

The Stakeholder Model

FORGE treats inmates as **stakeholders** who take ownership of dorm culture. Peer influence is redirected from harm toward **conflict resolution, accountability, and service** — complementing staff authority with a disciplined peer culture.

Standard 2-Hour Session

Check-in 10m	Review 10m	Core Instruction — 40 min	Practice / Exercise — 30 min	Debrief 20m	Close 10m

Program at a Glance

216	12-15	85%	60+	790+
Hours 36 weeks	Cohort per class	Attend. required	Field Hrs supervised	Pages curriculum

Accountability & Standards

- **Zero tolerance** for weapons, violence, intimidation, gang signaling
- **Code of Conduct** governs behavior in class, dorm, everywhere
- **Peer evaluation** at every phase gate
- **Staff observation** required for advancement
- **Removal** for violations protects program and facility safety

Certification: 6 Competencies

Every graduate is assessed across six areas. Certification requires **Proficient (3)** or higher in all.

Competency	What It Measures
Self-Awareness	Recognizes thinking errors & patterns
Emotional Regulation	Manages emotions under stress
Conflict Resolution	De-escalates and resolves disputes
Communication	Listens actively, facilitates discussion
Accountability	Owns mistakes, builds responsibility
Mentoring	Supports growth, facilitates independently

Ongoing Evaluation

Written Assessments
Knowledge checks at each phase gate

Simulation Scoring
Rubric-scored scenario performance

Peer Review
Cohort endorsement required to advance

Staff Observation
Facility staff flag concerns at each gate

Portfolio Review
Documented evidence of growth & skill

Review Board
Final panel evaluation for certification

Statistics from source programs. Full program details in the FORGE Program Overview at forgementors.org

Leadership is not assigned. It is forged.

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Purpose & Mission

FORGE is a peer-led, evidence-based mentorship program designed to build a safer, more stable dorm culture by training men to lead through service, accountability, and conflict reduction. The mission of FORGE is to develop mentors who lead by example, create environments where violence is discouraged, and live the principle of Service Over Self — turning time served into time that serves others.

FORGE is built around a simple but demanding leadership belief: leadership begins when individuals stop living only for themselves and take responsibility for building others. In a correctional environment, this means choosing restraint over reaction, accountability over avoidance, and stability over chaos.

> *"Leadership begins when individuals stop living only for themselves and take responsibility for building others."*

What FORGE Is

FORGE is a structured mentorship model designed to strengthen and support peer-led evidence-based programming. Its primary purpose is to prepare incarcerated individuals to become peer mentors who can safely and responsibly facilitate evidence-based programs in other dorms and housing units. The idea is to spread the virus. Only this virus is to help bring structure and safety to prisons.

Rather than relying on informal influence or personality-driven leadership, FORGE provides structure. Participants are trained to mentor others consistently, reduce conflict before it escalates into violence, model pro-social decision-making, and help establish a dorm culture defined by respect, accountability, and safety.

As described in the FORGE handbook, the program is about building a new prison experience — one where men lead by example, support one another, and prepare to make a positive impact both inside the facility and beyond it.

> Our Purpose: To build mentors who create a culture of peace, responsibility, and service — modeling the change we want to see in every community. Our goal is simple: to turn time served into time that serves others.

Core Principles of the FORGE Model

Service Over Self	Accountability	Conflict Reduction
Mentors prioritize dorm safety over personal interests. Leadership is demonstrated through daily acts of service and consistent, observable behavior.	Every participant is held to measurable standards. Attendance, conduct, peer evaluations, and staff observations determine advancement.	FORGE trains mentors to intervene early, de-escalate tension, and resolve disputes before they become violent incidents.
Evidence-Based Practice	**Peer Leadership**	**Self-Sustaining Design**
The curriculum draws from over 25 proven correctional programs backed by research and real-world outcomes across 8 states.	Trained mentors become facilitators for the next cohort, creating a pipeline of credible leaders who understand the environment.	Each graduating class trains the next, ensuring continuity and institutional knowledge transfer without outside dependency.

> What Makes FORGE Different: Unlike programs that rely on outside instructors or one-time workshops, FORGE creates a permanent infrastructure of trained peer mentors inside the facility. The program is built by incarcerated men, led by incarcerated men, and sustained by incarcerated men — with structure, accountability, and evidence-based methods that meet professional standards. FORGE does not wait for change to happen from the outside. It builds change from within, one mentor at a time, one cohort at a time, one dorm at a time.

The Stakeholder Model

FORGE is grounded in the reality that both staff and inmates will recognize: safety and rehabilitation are not automatic. They require work, daily choices, consistent expectations, and credible leadership inside housing units.

In the last 6 years, we as inmates have seen violence sky-rocket. Not just murders, but stabbings and fights, many of which are never even reported. Things must change. We all want to go home one day. This includes staff and inmates. Because of this, many of us see that we must take on some of the responsibilities to build our own rehabilitation system to create a safer environment to live in.

We've come to recognize that we are stakeholders in this system. Inmates do not want to be incarcerated. But many understand that the conditions they live in can be shaped heavily by peer behavior — how conflicts are handled, how pressure is applied, and whether violence is encouraged or discouraged. FORGE intends to channel this reality into a structured, accountable role where peer influence is used to reduce harm rather than amplify it. Where we build mentors that can facilitate peer-led rehabilitation programs in all the dorms at Dooly to change the prison experience.

The stakeholder model does not replace staff authority. It complements it by creating a disciplined peer culture that supports order rather than undermines it.

> ***"A dorm where trained mentors actively build peace is a dorm that is safer for everyone — inmates and staff alike."***

The FORGE Curriculum

FORGE has developed a comprehensive, 36-week curriculum organized into three phases. The program meets three times per week for two-hour sessions — 108 sessions and approximately 216 hours of structured training in total.

Phase 1: Foundation — "Know Yourself" (Weeks 1–12)	Phase 2: Development — "Build Others" (Weeks 13–24)	Phase 3: Practicum — "Lead and Serve" (Weeks 25–36)
Participants build self-awareness through cognitive behavioral skills, emotional regulation, trauma awareness, conflict resolution, and personal accountability. Before anyone can mentor others, they must first do their own work.	Personal growth becomes the ability to help others. Participants learn teaching and facilitation skills, motivational interviewing, simulation-based training with realistic dorm scenarios, and restorative justice practices.	Training becomes reality. Participants mentor under graduated supervision, co-lead sessions with the next incoming cohort, and work toward formal certification through a review board evaluation.

Each phase has specific gate requirements — including attendance, written assessments, peer evaluations, staff observations, and demonstrated competency — that must be met before advancing. The program culminates in a formal certification after completing 60 hours of supervised mentoring and facilitation.

The full curriculum includes over 790 pages of facilitator guides with session-by-session scripts, plus participant workbooks with exercises, reflection prompts, and tracking tools.

> Certification Requirements: To earn FORGE Mentor Certification, participants must complete all 108 sessions across three phases, pass written assessments and peer evaluations at each gate, accumulate 60+ hours of supervised mentoring and facilitation, receive satisfactory staff observation reports, and pass a formal review board evaluation.

216	108	36	790+	60+	3
Total Hours	Sessions	Weeks	Pages of Curriculum	Field Hours Required	Phases

> The Self-Sustaining Mentor Pipeline: Cohort 1 is trained by program founders → Graduates become certified mentors → Certified mentors co-facilitate Phase 1 for Cohort 2 → The cycle repeats, building permanent mentor infrastructure. Every cohort strengthens the program. No outside facilitators required after launch.

Evidence-Based Foundation

FORGE studied more than 25 successful correctional programs across 8 states and built its curriculum from proven, evidence-based sources:

- Thinking for a Change (T4C) — the National Institute of Corrections' cognitive behavioral curriculum, used widely across U.S. corrections
- Moral Reconation Therapy (MRT) — a cognitive-behavioral system focused on moral reasoning, backed by over 200 published outcome studies
- Seeking Safety — an evidence-based model for trauma awareness that does not require personal disclosure
- SAMHSA's Trauma-Informed Care Framework — providing the overarching principles of safety, trust, peer support, and empowerment
- GRIP (Guiding Rage Into Power) — a California program that informed FORGE's emotional literacy curriculum and normative culture approach
- MENTOR National Mentoring Partnership — providing the elements of effective mentoring practice

The program structure draws from models including PEP (Texas), RSVP (San Francisco), Defy Ventures, and the Oregon Mentors Certification Program.

What the Evidence Shows

GRIP	RSVP	Defy	T4C	RAND
0.5%	**80%**	**<10%**	**23%**	**$1→$5**
recidivism vs 41.9% avg	reduction in violent rearrests	recidivism; 85% employed	recidivism vs 36% control	ROI; 43% less recidivism

For a detailed breakdown, see the FORGE Program Overview at forgementors.org.

How FORGE Works

Leadership Through Service

FORGE defines leadership as responsibility, not status. Participants are trained to act in ways that make the dorm safer, the people around them more stable, and the overall environment more manageable.

Leadership in FORGE is demonstrated through daily behavior: being the example others can follow, serving the needs of the dorm before personal interests, protecting the culture from violence and intimidation, and passing knowledge forward to others. This is not symbolic leadership — it is practical, observable, and accountable.

> Safety is non-negotiable. Weapons, threats, and violence are not tolerated within the program. Possession of a weapon or promotion of violence results in removal from FORGE, without exception.

Standards That Stabilize Dorm Life

FORGE establishes clear dorm standards focused on respect, cleanliness, quiet, property boundaries, and safety. These standards are not about control for its own sake; they are about predictability and stability in a shared living environment.

Participants are taught that every action — how someone speaks, how they handle conflict, how they respect shared space — affects everyone else. When the environment is protected, tension decreases. When tension decreases, both safety and rehabilitation improve.

> FORGE Dorm Standards: Respect & Dignity — Treat all individuals with basic respect; no intimidation or manipulation; honor property boundaries; resolve disagreements without threats. Environment & Order — Maintain cleanliness in shared spaces; observe quiet hours and routines; follow dorm procedures; support consistent daily structure. Safety & Security — Zero tolerance for weapons; report genuine safety threats; de-escalate before situations grow; protect vulnerable individuals.

Operations & Staff Alignment

Conflict Resolution: De-escalation First

A central function of FORGE is teaching mentors how to reduce conflict quickly while preserving dignity. Participants are trained to recognize escalation early and intervene in ways that slow situations down rather than intensify them.

The conflict-resolution process emphasizes posture, tone, facts over assumptions, identifying needs and options, and checking back for resolution. Mentors are trained to avoid behaviors that increase risk, including threats, weapons talk, or claims of gang authority.

When a situation exceeds the scope of peer intervention or presents a safety concern, mentors are trained to disengage and refer appropriately. The goal is stability, not control.

Simulation-Based Training

A defining feature of FORGE is simulation-based training. Rather than relying solely on discussion, mentors practice responding to realistic scenarios that mirror the situations they face inside the facility and during reentry preparation.

Simulations mirror common dorm conflicts, manipulation and peer pressure, escalation triggers, ethical decision points, and reentry-related stressors. This approach allows mentors to practice judgment, communication, and restraint in controlled settings, reducing trial-and-error risk.

Trauma-Aware, Not Therapeutic

FORGE recognizes that stress and trauma influence behavior in correctional settings. While FORGE is not a clinical or counseling program, mentors are trained to recognize emotional escalation and respond in ways that avoid provocation or humiliation. This trauma-aware approach emphasizes dignity and de-escalation without placing mentors in therapeutic roles.

The Self-Sustaining Pipeline

FORGE is designed to renew itself. Certified mentors from each cohort become the facilitators for the next incoming cohort. This creates a permanent infrastructure of trained peer mentors that does not depend on outside facilitators to continue operating. The first cohort is trained by program founders; every cohort after that is trained by the men who came before them.

> The FORGE De-escalation Model: Recognize early signs of conflict → Approach with calm posture and tone → Focus on facts, not assumptions → Identify needs and options → Check back for resolution → Disengage and refer if safety is at risk.

Why Staff Should Care

FORGE is designed to support facility safety and operational goals. By training credible peer mentors, the program reduces dorm conflict through early de-escalation, reinforces consistent standards, discourages weapons and intimidation, and strengthens evidence-based programming by providing reliable facilitators.

The intended outcome is a safer, more stable environment where rehabilitation can actually take root — benefiting inmates and staff alike.

When trained mentors actively maintain dorm culture standards, staff can focus on their core responsibilities with the confidence that peer leaders are reinforcing — not undermining — institutional order. FORGE creates allies, not adversaries.

> Expected Outcomes: Reduced Conflict — Trained mentors de-escalate tensions before they reach staff, reducing incident reports and use-of-force situations. Consistent Standards — FORGE reinforces behavioral expectations 24/7 through peer culture. Reliable Facilitators — Certified mentors provide a sustainable pool of trained facilitators for evidence-based programs facility-wide. Safer Environment — A disciplined peer culture means less violence, fewer disruptions, and more predictable operations.

Accountability & Standards

Role Boundaries and Staff Alignment

FORGE explicitly defines mentor boundaries to protect staff authority and institutional integrity. Mentors do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, override staff decisions, or conceal safety concerns.

When situations involve weapons, threats, or serious escalation, mentors are trained to step back and refer appropriately. Safety always takes priority over peer resolution.

Mentors DO	Mentors DO NOT
• De-escalate conflicts using trained techniques • Model pro-social behavior daily • Maintain dorm culture standards • Facilitate evidence-based sessions • Refer safety concerns appropriately • Support and reinforce institutional order	• Investigate incidents or gather intelligence • Impose discipline or sanctions • Override or challenge staff decisions • Conceal safety concerns or threats • Act as enforcers or authority figures • Use position for personal advantage

Code of Conduct and Accountability

FORGE operates under a clear Code of Conduct that sets expectations for integrity, service, learning, safety, and community behavior. Violence, intimidation, weapons, and gang signaling are explicitly prohibited.

Accountability is essential to program credibility. When standards are violated, participants are removed to protect the integrity of the program and the safety of the dorm.

> Zero-Tolerance Standards: Possession of weapons, promotion of violence, intimidation, gang signaling, and any behavior that undermines dorm safety result in immediate removal from the program. There are no warnings for actions that threaten the safety of others.

Inclusion, Fairness, and Accountability

FORGE recognizes differences in age, background, sentence length, and experience. Leadership is based on conduct, consistency, and accountability — not status, seniority, or influence.

Participation in FORGE is a responsibility that must be maintained through behavior. Violations result in removal to protect program integrity and facility safety.

Measuring Results

The FORGE program will provide data-rich information on the success of each class and the program alike for evaluating all outcomes, including trends in incidents, mentor participation and completion, program engagement, and qualitative feedback from staff and participants.

Metric	What Is Tracked	Purpose
Incident Trends	Dorm-level conflict, violence, and disciplinary reports before and during FORGE	Measure impact on dorm safety and stability
Participation	Attendance rates, session completion, gate advancement, and cohort graduation rates	Track engagement and program throughput
Mentor Performance	Peer evaluations, staff observations, facilitation quality, and mentee outcomes	Ensure mentor quality and accountability
Qualitative Feedback	Staff impressions, participant reflections, and peer assessments of dorm culture changes	Capture nuanced impacts beyond numbers

> Continuous Improvement: FORGE is committed to transparent reporting. All data is available for review by facility administration, oversight bodies, and stakeholders. The program adapts based on measurable outcomes, ensuring that methods remain effective and responsive to the needs of participants and staff.

FORGE is not about control.
It is about responsibility.

FORGE is more than a program. It is a disciplined approach to building a safer culture through responsibility, restraint, and service. By recognizing that we are stakeholders, FORGE strengthens peer leadership, reduces instability, supports evidence-based programming, contributes to safer, more manageable housing units, and supports rehabilitation efforts at Dooly State Prison.

We believe that the men inside these walls have the capacity to lead, to serve, and to change — not just for themselves, but for every person who shares this space and every community waiting for them on the other side.

Every cohort that graduates strengthens the foundation. Every mentor who is certified extends the reach. Every conflict that is resolved without violence proves the model works. This is not theory. This is practice. This is FORGE.

Leadership is not granted.

It is forged.

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